

Incident: Walk-in Compressor Failure

Owner: Samuel Okafor (Sous Chef, Prep)

1) Scope and purpose

- Applies to Prep station leads and openers; supports Grill, Pastry, and Front of House by protecting TCS product.
- Goal: keep cold-holding at 41°F or below, act fast on alarms or temp deviations, document waste, and restore service safely.

2) Incident summary (kept exact)

- When: overnight, discovered at 6:10 AM opening. Reported by: Samuel Okafor.
- Walk-in air read 52°F at opening; product probes 47–49°F. Alarm had not paged anyone because the notification phone number was out of date.
- 180 lb of TCS product discarded ($\approx$ \$1,940).
- PolarServ on site at 11:05 AM; compressor contactor replaced.
- Follow-ups:
 - Alarm contact list updated (owner: Kitchen Manager).
 - SOP: Walk-in Cooler Temperature Alarm Response written.

3) Food safety disposition rules (use on discovery)

- Cold-hold target: 41°F or below.
- If time above 41°F is unknown, discard TCS product.
- If product is 42–70°F for more than 4 hours, discard.
- If product is 42–70°F for less than 4 hours and time is verified, rapidly cool to 41°F within 2 hours max; otherwise discard.
- Never refreeze thawed product that exceeded 41°F beyond allowable time.
- Prioritize product-probe temperatures over air temp for disposition.

Condition on discovery	Action	Notes
Air 41°F or below; product 41°F or below	Keep	Log temps and proceed
Air above 41°F; product 41°F or below	Keep, monitor	Investigate unit; recheck hourly
Product 42–70°F; exposure time unknown	Discard	Applies to this incident

Product 42–70°F; verified < 4 h	Rapid chill to 41°F ≤ 2 h	Ice bath, blast chiller if available
Product above 70°F	Discard	Do not attempt to cool

4) Immediate response procedure (on any walk-in temp issue)

1. Don't open the door unless necessary. Kill lights to reduce heat load.
2. Read air temp on the walk-in display. Record time and temp in the log.
3. Probe 5 items in different zones and heights (top, mid, bottom; near door and back). Record each product temp.
4. Use the disposition table. If time above 41°F is unknown, discard affected TCS immediately.
5. Tag and isolate bins slated for discard. Weigh by category (proteins, dairy, cooked starches, produce, sauces). Record total pounds and estimated cost.
6. Call Kitchen Manager, Sous Chef on duty, and GM. If no answer in 5 minutes, escalate to next contact on the list.
7. Call service vendor. Provide: unit ID/location (main walk-in), symptoms (air 52°F; product 47–49°F), last seen normal, doors usage, any compressor noises or ice.
8. Place backup cold-hold: move any safe product to other refrigeration (lowboys, backup reach-ins) without overloading. Space pans for airflow.
9. Post a HOLD sign on the walk-in door: "Do not use—service en route." Control access.
10. Start a recovery log: temps, calls made, actions taken, weights discarded, vendor ETA.

5) Troubleshooting and verification (before vendor arrives)

- Check power: breaker on, unit powered, fans running.
- Listen/look: compressor running? condenser/evaporator fans on? unusual clicks (contactor chatter), ice on coils, doors sealing, curtains intact.
- Check door gasket seal with a dollar-bill pull; fix obvious obstructions.
- Ensure no hot pans or uncovered liquids were loaded.
- Verify alarm hardware: panel powered, sensor intact, network light on.
- Do not reset or override safeties unless directed by maintenance or vendor.
- If temps continue to rise, relocate all keepable product to alternate units and recheck temps every 30 minutes.

6) Communication and alarms

- The alarm had not paged anyone because the notification phone number was out of date.

- Alarm contact list updated (owner: Kitchen Manager). Verify numbers weekly and after any staffing change.
- Call tree (execute in order until contact is reached):
 - Kitchen Manager
 - Samuel Okafor (Sous Chef, Prep)
 - Sous Chef on duty
 - GM
- Document all calls with time and result in the recovery log.

7) Vendor coordination

- PolarServ on site at 11:05 AM; compressor contactor replaced.
- When calling service, request:
 - Tech ETA and callback 15 minutes prior to arrival.
 - Parts on truck for likely failures: contactor, start capacitor, fan motors, defrost timer.
 - Post-repair verification: air temp back to $\leq 38\text{--}40^{\circ}\text{F}$ within target pull-down, product spot checks $\leq 41^{\circ}\text{F}$.
- After repair: sanitize door handles and shelves, remove any meltwater, and restart temperature logging.

8) Waste, inventory, and recovery for Prep

- 180 lb of TCS product discarded ($\approx \$1,940$). Record each category weight and cost in the waste log; attach photos of thermometer readings and product labels.
- Pull-forward plan:
 - Re-prep highest-impact mise first: dressings, sauces, cooked grains, cut veg, proteins for service pars.
 - Use backup frozen stocks and unopened, factory-sealed items held $\leq 41^{\circ}\text{F}$.
 - Stagger batches to avoid overloading cooling capacity; chill finished prep to 41°F within 2 hours in shallow pans or ice baths.
- Purchasing:
 - Submit rush order for discarded items with par plus 10% buffer until walk-in performance is stable.

9) Monitoring and prevention

- Cold-hold targets: air $38\text{--}40^{\circ}\text{F}$; product $\leq 41^{\circ}\text{F}$.

- Do not block evaporator airflow. Leave at least 6 inches clearance from walls and fans.
- Daily checks (log results):

Check	Open (6:00–7:00 AM)	Mid (2:00–3:00 PM)	Close (10:00–11:00 PM)
Walk-in air temp	Record	Record	Record
Two product probes (different shelves)	Record	Record	Record
Door gasket/closure	Inspect	—	Inspect
Alarm panel status light	Verify	—	Verify
Contact list posted by panel	Verify	—	Verify

- Weekly:
 - Verify alarm call/text by running a test page to all listed numbers.
 - Clean condenser coils, clear drains, check door sweep and strip curtains.
 - Review temp logs; retrain if any out-of-range readings lack corrective action.

10) Documentation checklist

- Recovery log completed with times, temps, photos, calls, vendor ETA/arrival, repair details.
- Waste log with 180 lb total and cost ($\approx$ \$1,940); attach category breakdown.
- SOP: Walk-in Cooler Temperature Alarm Response referenced in shift notes and posted at the alarm panel.
- Post-incident debrief with Prep, Grill, Pastry, and Front of House to align on par rebuild and service impacts.